BISC Trendency Research:
Care Economy Research Memo
September 2025

Key Takeaways

Voters with lived experience drive support for public care policies.

- Voters who have personally struggled—or know someone who has struggled—to afford or access childcare, elder care, or paid time off are consistently more supportive of government action across all care policies. Responses to this "experience" question are polarized, with 36% rating it very true for them (80–100 on the scale) and 30% saying it is not true at all (0–19).
- Women, younger voters, Latine and Indigenous voters, Democrats, rural residents, and those earning under $75,000 per year are the most likely to report lived experience with care struggles. Republicans, voters aged 65 or older, Asian/AAPI voters, suburban residents, and higher-income households are the least likely. This sharp divide shows how centering real stories of families struggling to pay for care can help advocates move undecided or skeptical audiences.

Rising housing costs push voters to demand care solutions.

- Housing costs, healthcare and prescription drug costs, low wages, and saving for retirement remain the top issues shaping voters' sense of financial security across BISC's 14 priority states. Since the summer of 2021, concern about housing costs has increased substantially (+7 overall), with the largest jump among voters earning less than $75,000 annually (+4). By contrast, higher-income voters are now more likely to point to healthcare and prescription drug costs (+3).
- State patterns are distinct: housing costs weigh most heavily in Oregon, Nevada, Colorado, and Florida; healthcare and prescriptions are top concerns in Montana, Michigan, and Ohio; and wages not being high enough is especially pronounced in Mississippi. Nevada stands out for voters naming caregiving for parents as a key burden, while voters in Arizona and Florida are the most likely to report no major financial concerns. These pressures help explain where and why voters are more open to policy solutions that ease care costs.

Voters sustain high concern about public education funding.

- On average, voters rate their concern about public education funding at 60 out of 100, with more than one-third (36%) saying they are extremely concerned (80+), and only 15% reporting little or no concern (0–19). Concern is most pronounced among

Democrats, urban voters, and Black voters, while non-college-educated voters, Independents, and Republicans express less worry.
- State differences are modest: voters in Michigan and Oregon are the most concerned, while those in Florida and Washington report slightly lower levels. Importantly, concern about education funding has remained remarkably consistent since early 2020, suggesting it is a durable issue that can reliably anchor broader conversations about investments in care and families.

Supportive voters position childcare cost measures to pass.

- If childcare affordability were on the ballot today across the 14 states, Trendency's "Election Day Rating" suggests it would likely pass, though volatility remains high. More than half of voters (54%) lean strongly toward supporting such a measure, compared to just 17% who lean strongly toward opposing it.
- Support is strongest among Democrats, Black voters, younger voters, and women, while Independents, Republicans, and Asian/AAPI voters are less enthusiastic. However, even among these more skeptical groups, there is little outright opposition.
- Support for childcare cost measures is strongest in Nebraska, Missouri, and Montana, while Arizona and Florida voters remain more cautious.
- Voters with direct care experience are especially decisive—58% of those who say the experience statement is very true for them would almost certainly vote yes, compared to just 28% among those who say the statement does not apply. The challenge for advocates is not overcoming hardened resistance, but growing the intensity of support, particularly by lifting up real stories about how care costs strain families.

Caregivers' experiences shift voters toward government action on childcare.

- When asked whether government should guarantee affordable childcare or stay out of childcare decisions, voters lean slightly toward supporting a government guarantee of affordable childcare, but this support is conditional and closely tied to lived experience. Those with direct care struggles are far more likely to back government action, while voters without such experiences are more skeptical and often prefer government stay out. One-third (33%) strongly believe government should guarantee childcare, while 23% strongly believe it should stay out altogether.
- Among voters who say the care economy experience statement is very true for them, nearly half (48%) strongly support a guarantee, but among those who say it is not true, almost two in five (39%) strongly want government to stay out.
- State patterns reinforce these divides: Montana, Oregon, and Michigan lean toward supporting a government guarantee, while Arizona and Florida tilt toward government staying out. For advocates, these findings suggest that framing childcare as a practical solution rooted in families' lived experience is essential to winning over undecided audiences.

Voters back government action on elder care more than on childcare.

- While childcare divides voters, elder care garners broader consensus, though support varies in intensity and by demographics. Republicans and voters opposed to new taxes

are less supportive, though even in these groups outright opposition remains relatively low. Across the 14 states, a clear majority (56%) lean toward saying government should guarantee affordable elder care, while just 19% strongly favor government staying out.
- Even among voters who oppose new taxes, attitudes are mixed rather than firmly negative—38% in this group strongly prefer "stay out," but nearly one-quarter remain undecided.
- States like Michigan, Montana, and Maine are the most supportive of government involvement, while Missouri, Arizona, and Florida are less so. Compared to childcare, opposition to government's role in elder care is both lower in intensity and less widespread, making elder care a safer and more persuasive entry point for talking about the broader care economy.

Voters overwhelmingly support expanding affordable elder housing.

- Expanding affordable housing options for older adults is one of the most popular care policies tested, averaging 72 out of 100 across all voters, but support is not uniform. Republicans and 'no new tax' voters are less likely to strongly support it, even as Democrats and women drive higher averages. More than half of voters (52%) strongly support it (80+), while only 10% strongly oppose (0–19). Importantly, about one-third (31%) fall in the middle, suggesting there is room for advocates to grow support even further.
- State support is highest in Mississippi, Nebraska, Montana, and Maine, with somewhat lower averages in California, Arizona, and Washington. While Democrats and women lead support for elder housing, even voters who oppose new taxes or government's role in care are more often polarized than united in opposition.
- Advocates can confidently advance elder housing policies as a broadly popular, cross-partisan solution that makes the care economy tangible.

Voters across parties rally behind paid sick leave.

- Paid sick leave is the most widely supported care policy, though intensity is higher among Democrats, Black voters, women, and urban residents. Men, Republicans, Indigenous voters, and Asian/AAPI voters are less supportive, though even in these groups opposition is soft rather than hardened. Few voters strongly reject government involvement (16%), which underscores that the challenge is not defeating entrenched opposition but ensuring strong turnout and engagement from supportive groups.
- Nebraska, Montana, and Oregon voters are the most enthusiastic about guaranteeing paid sick leave, while Arizona and Ohio show weaker, though still net positive, support.
- Voters who back paid sick leave also see family leave policies as a clear positive for their state, reinforcing that this policy is an effective starting point for building confidence in the broader care agenda.

Partisan divides shape voter views on family and medical leave.

- Like paid sick leave, voters generally support ensuring access to paid family and medical leave for childbirth, caregiving, and serious health needs, but the partisan divide is sharper.
- A slim majority (53%) lean toward government ensuring access, while one in four (25%) lean toward leaving it to employers. Nearly one in five voters remain undecided. Partisanship shapes this divide most clearly: Democrats overwhelmingly support a government role, while Republicans are more inclined to leave family leave decisions to employers.
- Nebraska, Oregon, Michigan, and Washington show the highest levels of support for government-guaranteed family and medical leave, while Arizona remains the one state where voters are truly split down the middle.
- Importantly, voters who back government action see family leave as a major positive for their state (58% rate it 80+), while just 6% of those who want it left to employers feel the same. Arizona is the one state where voters are split down the middle, highlighting where advocates must be especially careful in framing.

Voters show mixed support for investing in care workers' wages and conditions.

- Voters are divided on whether public funding should be used to increase wages and improve working conditions for childcare and home care workers. On average, voters rate support at 54 out of 100, with nearly three in ten (29%) strongly supportive, but almost one-quarter (24%) strongly opposed.
- Age is the sharpest dividing line: younger voters are far more supportive, while one-third of voters over 65 are firmly opposed. Democrats, Black and Latine voters, and those under 45 are the strongest supporters, while Republicans, older voters, and Asian/AAPI voters are the least supportive. State-level results show Mississippi voters are the most supportive of investing in care workers, while voters in Nevada, Ohio, Michigan, and Arizona are more skeptical.
- This issue remains a live debate with room to grow support, especially by lifting up the critical role care workers play in keeping families and communities thriving.

Voters favor taxing wealth and corporations but show signs of tax fatigue.

- When asked about policy priorities, voters spread their attention across multiple needs, but lowering taxes for families emerged as the single most popular option (23 points on average). Still, large segments prioritize improving access to healthcare, protecting public schools, and making childcare more affordable, especially among Democrats, Black voters, and Asian/AAPI voters.
- On revenue, taxing extreme wealth and large corporations are the most popular sources for funding care investments, with nearly half of voters allocating 40 or more points to taxing extreme wealth. Yet "no new taxes" is also a popular response, especially among Republicans and older voters, with the highest opposition found in Michigan, Arizona, and Florida.
- While voters support taxing extreme wealth and large corporations to fund care, 78% also report some level of fatigue with being asked to pay more in taxes—even for programs they value. Agreement with this "tax exhaustion" sentiment averages 57 out

of 100 across all voters. Republicans express the highest exhaustion, with more than half (52%) rating it very true (80+), followed by independents (42%), while only about one in five Democrats feel the same. Democrats are more likely to reject the statement outright, with 35% saying it is not true for them at all (0–19).

- When asked to choose, voters split between prioritizing keeping taxes low and ensuring families have care, with partisanship driving the divide. Democrats lean heavily toward care, Republicans toward low taxes, and independents remain divided—suggesting this frame is a core tension point in care economy debates. These findings underscore the importance of pairing new revenue proposals with fairness frames and visible benefits for families.

Research Methodology

Baseline Care Economy Trendency Report & Analysis (September 2025)

BISC's 2025 Baseline Reports consist of data on questions that are active across all of BISC's 14 priority campaign state panels, conducted and managed by Trendency Research (AZ, CA, CO, FL, ME, MI, MS,MO, MT, NE, NV, OH, OR, and WA). This report features a combination of new and existing questions; existing questions go back as far as September 2017, while the new questions were activated on August 6, 2025. Data was pulled from August 28-September 2, 2025; these questions were part of a larger queue of baseline and state-specific questions set at various priorities and frequencies, which means that each voter receives a bespoke survey made especially for them and changes depending on where they live and how often they log on to the platform. Since the data was pulled over the course of multiple days, averages featured throughout this report may be slightly different due to daily fluctuations in the data. The sample size was approximately 12,000 registered voters.

BISC Approach to Research

BISC's mission is to strengthen democracy by implementing a national progressive strategy for ballot measures rooted in building state-based power. We center the following principles when approaching our research program:

1. We conduct comprehensive research that includes quantitative and qualitative methodologies.
2. We collect data that gives us insight to a snapshot in time (like most traditional polling and focus groups) and we collect longitudinal data to give us insight over time through our Trendency panels.
3. We conduct research in the multi-modal ways that people access data, including text messaging, social media and online methodologies for gauging opinions.
4. We conduct research that allows for more complexity and nuance, utilizing scale - seeing participants as multi-dimensional, rather than binary beings.
5. We conduct research that helps us disrupt "monolith" narratives and strategies for BIPOC, immigrant and youth communities, to understand in more depth what is important to these traditionally underrepresented people -- the people we center in our long-term, movement building work.

Contact Us

For more information, or if you have any questions, please contact Adam Snipes, Director of Strategic Partnerships at adam@ballot.org.

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